



The Influence of Influencer Marketing, Social Proof, Fear of Missing Out, and User-Generated Content on Purchase Decisions on TikTok Shop with Platform Trust as a Moderating Variable: A Study of Generation Z in Indonesia

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Abstract

This study investigates the effects of influencer marketing, social proof, fear of missing out (FOMO), and user-generated content (UGC) on purchase decisions on TikTok Shop, with platform trust examined as a moderating variable among Generation Z consumers in Indonesia. The study responds to the growing role of social commerce, where short-form video, peer validation, algorithmic exposure, and embedded transaction features jointly shape digital consumer behavior. A quantitative explanatory design was used. Primary data were collected through an online questionnaire from 120 Generation Z respondents who had active TikTok accounts and had purchased products through TikTok Shop. The measurement instrument used a seven-point Likert scale, and the data were analyzed using Partial Least Squares-Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM). The measurement model met the requirements for convergent validity, discriminant validity, and internal consistency reliability. The structural model showed strong explanatory power, with an R-square value of 0.790 for purchase decisions. The results reveal that social proof has a positive and significant effect on purchase decisions ($\beta = 0.328$; $t = 3.477$; $p < 0.001$), UGC has a positive and significant effect ($\beta = 0.340$; $t = 3.283$; $p = 0.001$), and platform trust also has a positive and significant effect ($\beta = 0.266$; $t = 2.649$; $p = 0.004$). In contrast, influencer marketing does not significantly affect purchase decisions ($\beta = 0.053$; $t = 0.653$; $p = 0.257$), and FOMO also does not show a significant effect ($\beta = -0.068$; $t = 1.033$; $p = 0.151$). Platform trust does not significantly moderate the effects of influencer marketing, social proof, FOMO, or UGC on purchase decisions. These findings indicate that Generation Z consumers on TikTok Shop rely more on authentic peer-based information and platform credibility than on influencer persuasion or urgency-based emotional pressure.

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Keywords: Influencer Marketing, Social Proof, Fear of Missing Out, User-Generated Content, Platform Trust, Purchase Decision, TikTok Shop, Generation Z

1. INTRODUCTION

Digital technology has substantially transformed consumer behavior, particularly in the way consumers search for information, evaluate products, and make purchase decisions. Social media platforms no longer function merely as communication channels; they have evolved into integrated commercial environments where product discovery, social interaction, persuasive content, and transactions occur simultaneously. The expansion of internet access and the acceleration of digital commerce have marked a new phase of online business activity, especially in e-commerce and social commerce (Lodhi & Sharma, 2023; Zhang et al., 2024). In Indonesia, these developments are particularly relevant because the digital population is large and increasingly accustomed to mobile-based shopping activities.

The thesis data indicate that internet penetration in Indonesia reached 80.66% in 2025, with the highest penetration recorded in Java, followed by Kalimantan, Sumatra, Bali and Nusa Tenggara, and Sulawesi. This pattern shows that digital connectivity has become a dominant part of Indonesian social and economic life. The high level of internet penetration also provides a fertile environment for the growth of social commerce, in which consumers are exposed not only to marketplace features but also to reviews, ratings, influencer content, and user-generated product experiences.

TikTok Shop is an important context for this study because it combines entertainment-based content with direct purchasing features. Unlike conventional e-commerce platforms, TikTok Shop enables consumers to encounter products while watching short videos, live streams, influencer recommendations, user reviews, and algorithmically personalized content. This creates a consumer journey that is fast, interactive, socially visible, and emotionally engaging. Such a setting is particularly relevant to Generation Z, who are generally active social media users and are highly responsive to visual, interactive, and trend-based digital content (Priporas et al., 2017).

In digital consumer behavior, purchase decisions are shaped by the interaction between internal psychological factors and external digital stimuli. Solomon (2020) explains that consumer behavior reflects the interaction of motivation, perception, attitudes, emotions, and social influence. In digital environments, this process is increasingly dynamic because consumers receive information from multiple sources in real time. Chaffey and Ellis-Chadwick (2019) also emphasize that digital platforms integrate communication, promotion, and transaction mechanisms in one ecosystem, allowing consumers to





participate actively in value creation through reviews, comments, and user-generated content.

This study focuses on four digital-marketing and social-psychological stimuli: influencer marketing, social proof, fear of missing out (FOMO), and user-generated content (UGC). Influencer marketing may shape consumer perceptions through the credibility, attractiveness, expertise, and perceived authenticity of social media figures (Ohanian, 1990; Reinikainen et al., 2020; Sokolova & Kefi, 2020). Social proof may reduce uncertainty by showing ratings, reviews, recommendations, and the number of products sold (Cheung & Thadani, 2012; Erkan & Evans, 2018; Filieri, 2015). FOMO may create psychological pressure when consumers feel that they might miss trends, promotions, or limited opportunities (Elhai et al., 2021; Przybylski et al., 2013). UGC may support purchase decisions because it is often perceived as more authentic and experience-based than seller-controlled promotional messages (Geng & Chen, 2021; Muntinga et al., 2018).

However, the effectiveness of these stimuli may depend on trust in the platform. In online transactions, consumers face risks related to product mismatch, payment security, data protection, seller credibility, and refund mechanisms. Platform trust therefore becomes an important factor in reducing perceived risk and strengthening confidence in digital transactions (D. J. Kim et al., 2008; McKnight et al., 2002). In social commerce, trust is especially important because social interaction and transaction processes occur within the same platform environment (Hajli et al., 2017).

Previous studies have reported mixed findings regarding the role of influencer marketing and FOMO in shaping purchase decisions. Some studies indicate that influencer marketing and FOMO positively affect consumer decisions, while others show weak or insignificant effects depending on platform characteristics, consumer literacy, trust, and perceived authenticity (Alfarisi & Sukaris, 2024; Purnomo, 2023; Sokolova & Kefi, 2020). This inconsistency shows that further empirical analysis is needed, particularly in the context of TikTok Shop and Generation Z in Indonesia. Accordingly, this study examines the effects of influencer marketing, social proof, FOMO, and UGC on purchase decisions on TikTok Shop, and tests whether platform trust moderates those relationships.

Table 1. Internet penetration in Indonesia by island group in 2025

Island Group	Internet Penetration (%)
Java	84.69
Kalimantan	78.72





Island Group	Internet Penetration (%)
Sumatra	77.12
Bali & Nusa Tenggara	76.86
Sulawesi	71.64

Source: APJII (2025), as reported in Detiklnet (2025).

2. LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Stimulus-Organism-Response and Digital Consumer Behavior

The Stimulus-Organism-Response (S-O-R) model explains how external stimuli influence internal psychological states and subsequently produce behavioral responses. In digital marketing, stimuli may include platform design, persuasive content, social interaction, product reviews, and promotional features. Huang and Benyoucef (2017) argue that social commerce design affects consumers by shaping cognitive and affective responses that lead to purchase decision-making. Similarly, A. J. Kim and Johnson (2016) demonstrate that social media-based marketing stimuli can influence consumers through perceptions and emotional responses before leading to behavioral outcomes.

In the present study, influencer marketing, social proof, FOMO, and UGC are positioned as digital stimuli within TikTok Shop. These stimuli are expected to influence Generation Z consumers through cognitive processes such as perceived credibility, usefulness, relevance, and trust, as well as affective processes such as interest, urgency, anxiety, and emotional attachment. The response is represented by purchase decisions. The model is also supported by Digital Consumer Behavior Theory, which explains that consumer decisions in digital environments are increasingly shaped by interactive information flows, peer validation, algorithmic exposure, and social influence (Solomon, 2020).

2.2 Social Influence and Online Trust

Social Influence Theory explains that individual attitudes and behaviors may be shaped through compliance, identification, and internalization (Kelman, 1958). This theory is highly relevant to TikTok Shop because consumer decisions are often influenced by visible social cues. Consumers may identify with influencers, comply with majority opinions through ratings and sales volume, or internalize information from authentic user experiences. Therefore, influencer marketing, social proof, FOMO, and UGC can be understood as manifestations of social influence in a digital shopping environment.





Online trust theory explains that trust reduces uncertainty and perceived risk in digital transactions. Mayer et al. (1995) conceptualize trust through ability, benevolence, and integrity, while McKnight et al. (2002) explain that online trust involves trusting beliefs and trusting intentions in e-commerce settings. In TikTok Shop, platform trust reflects consumer confidence that the platform can provide secure transactions, protect personal data, maintain system reliability, and provide fair refund mechanisms. Trust is therefore examined not only as a direct predictor of purchase decisions but also as a potential moderating variable.

2.3 Purchase Decision

Purchase decision refers to the stage in consumer decision-making in which consumers choose and buy a product after recognizing needs, searching for information, and evaluating alternatives. Kotler and Keller (2016) explain that purchase decision is the actual selection of a product, brand, or channel after consumers evaluate available options. In digital contexts, purchase decisions are shaped by rational evaluation, emotional responses, social information, convenience, and trust in the transaction environment (Fatmawati et al., 2023; Solomon, 2020). In this study, purchase decision is measured through confidence in buying products, firmness in product choice, final buying decision, and willingness to recommend products purchased on TikTok Shop.

2.4 Influencer Marketing

Influencer marketing is a digital marketing strategy that uses influential social media figures to deliver product information, experience-based narratives, and recommendations to followers. The effectiveness of influencer marketing is related to credibility, expertise, attractiveness, and authenticity (Ohanian, 1990; Reinikainen et al., 2020). Parasocial interaction theory also suggests that repeated exposure to influencers may create perceived closeness between audiences and influencers, which can enhance trust and persuasion (Sokolova & Kefi, 2020). However, influencer marketing may not always lead directly to purchase decisions when consumers are critical of sponsored content or when peer-based evidence is considered more reliable. Therefore, the following hypothesis is proposed: H1: Influencer marketing has a positive and significant effect on purchase decisions.

2.5 Social Proof

Social proof refers to the tendency of consumers to use other people's behavior, reviews, ratings, and recommendations as cues when evaluating products under uncertainty. In e-commerce and social commerce, social proof is reflected through online





reviews, product ratings, comments, recommendations, and sales volume. Cheung and Thadani (2012) and Erkan and Evans (2018) show that electronic word-of-mouth can affect consumers' perceptions and purchase intentions because it is perceived as more credible than firm-generated communication. Ahn and Lee (2024) and Kwakye et al. (2024) also show that online reviews and user comments influence purchase intentions by reducing risk and increasing confidence. Accordingly, H2: Social proof has a positive and significant effect on purchase decisions.

2.6 Fear of Missing Out (FOMO)

FOMO is a psychological condition characterized by anxiety that one may miss valuable experiences, trends, information, or opportunities enjoyed by others (Przybylski et al., 2013). In social commerce, FOMO may emerge through limited-time promotions, viral products, countdown timers, real-time purchase notifications, and trend-based exposure. Elhai et al. (2021) explain that FOMO is associated with continuous monitoring of social information and the desire to remain connected with current trends. In TikTok Shop, FOMO may accelerate decision-making by reducing the time consumers spend evaluating products. Therefore, H3: FOMO has a positive and significant effect on purchase decisions.

2.7 User-Generated Content

UGC refers to content created by consumers based on product experiences, such as reviews, comments, photos, unboxing videos, and product-use demonstrations. The COBRA framework explains that consumers engage with brands online through consuming, contributing, and creating brand-related content (Muntinga et al., 2018). In TikTok Shop, UGC is important because consumers can observe real experiences from other users before making decisions. Geng and Chen (2021) show that UGC can influence purchase intention because it is perceived as credible, relevant, useful, and authentic. Therefore, H4: UGC has a positive and significant effect on purchase decisions.

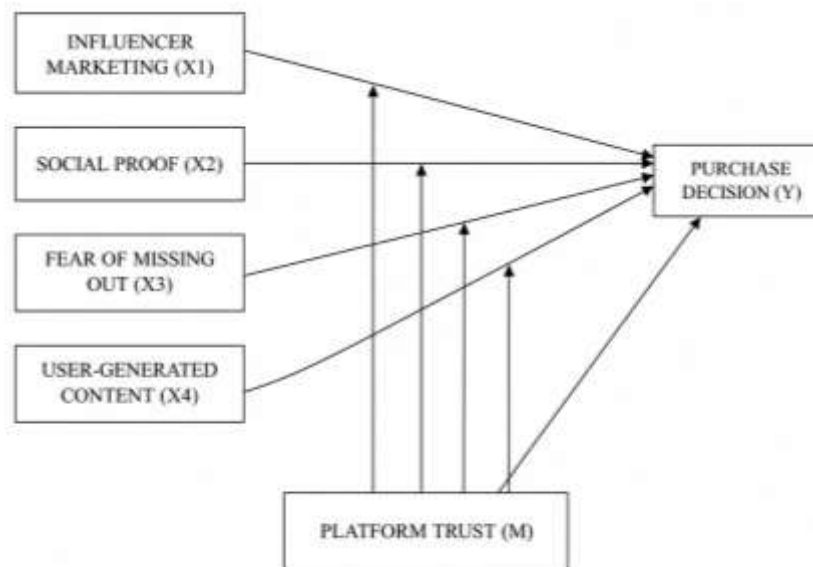
2.8 Platform Trust as Direct and Moderating Variable

Platform trust refers to consumers' confidence that a digital platform is secure, reliable, and responsible in facilitating online transactions. Trust reduces perceived risk and strengthens confidence in online purchase decisions (D. J. Kim et al., 2008; Y. Kim & Peterson, 2017). In social commerce, platform trust may also strengthen the influence of social stimuli because consumers are more likely to respond to reviews, influencer content, and user-generated information when the platform is perceived as trustworthy (Alkhalifah, 2022; Hajli et al., 2017). Therefore, this study proposes H5: Platform trust has a positive and



significant effect on purchase decisions. The study also proposes four moderating hypotheses: H6: Platform trust moderates the effect of influencer marketing on purchase decisions; H7: Platform trust moderates the effect of social proof on purchase decisions; H8: Platform trust moderates the effect of FOMO on purchase decisions; and H9: Platform trust moderates the effect of UGC on purchase decisions.

Figure 1. Conceptual framework of the study



3. RESEARCH METHOD

This study used a quantitative explanatory research design. The quantitative approach was selected because the study examines relationships among latent variables using numerical data and statistical procedures. The explanatory design was selected because the research aims to test the effects of influencer marketing, social proof, FOMO, UGC, and platform trust on purchase decisions, as well as the moderating role of platform trust. The use of explanatory quantitative research is appropriate for testing theoretically derived hypotheses in behavioral and marketing research (Creswell & Creswell, 2018; Sekaran & Bougie, 2020).

The population consisted of Generation Z consumers in Indonesia who use TikTok Shop and have purchased products through the platform. Because the exact population size is not known and the study requires respondents with specific digital-shopping experience, non-probability sampling with purposive sampling was used. The respondent criteria were: (1) aged 17-29 years, (2) having an active TikTok account, and (3) having completed at least one

purchase transaction through TikTok Shop. The final sample consisted of 120 respondents, meeting the minimum sample requirement for PLS-SEM based on the rule of five times the number of indicators (Hair et al., 2022).

Primary data were collected through an online questionnaire distributed using Google Forms. All variables were measured using a seven-point Likert scale ranging from 1 = strongly disagree to 7 = strongly agree. The data were analyzed using Partial Least Squares-Structural Equation Modeling (PLS-SEM). The analysis included descriptive statistics, measurement model evaluation, structural model evaluation, hypothesis testing, and moderation testing. The measurement model was assessed using outer loading, Average Variance Extracted (AVE), Heterotrait-Monotrait Ratio (HTMT), Cronbach's Alpha, and Composite Reliability. The structural model was evaluated through R-square, f-square, Q-square, path coefficients, t-statistics, and p-values (Hair et al., 2019, 2022).

Table 2. Respondent characteristics

Characteristic	Category	Frequency	Percentage
Age	17-20 years	18	15.0%
Age	21-23 years	75	62.5%
Age	24-29 years	27	22.5%
Occupation	Student	84	70.0%
Occupation	Private employee	22	18.3%
Occupation	Entrepreneur	8	6.7%
Occupation	Teacher	2	1.7%
Occupation	Other individual categories	4	3.2%
Income / allowance	< IDR 2,000,000 / month	45	37.5%
Income / allowance	IDR 2,000,000-IDR 5,000,000 / month	62	51.7%
Income / allowance	> IDR 5,000,000 / month	13	10.8%



Characteristic	Category	Frequency	Percentage
Region / island	Java	66	55.0%
Region / island	Kalimantan	7	5.8%
Region / island	Sumatra	11	9.2%
Region / island	Bali & Nusa Tenggara	31	25.8%
Region / island	Sulawesi	5	4.2%

Table 3. Operationalization of research variables

Variable	Code	Indicators	Main Sources
Influencer Marketing	X1	Credibility, expertise, attractiveness, authenticity and content closeness	Ohanian (1990); Reinikainen et al. (2020); Sokolova & Kefi (2020)
Social Proof	X2	Positive reviews and comments, product rating, user recommendations, number of products sold	Cheung & Thadani (2012); Erkan & Evans (2018); Filieri (2015)
Fear of Missing Out	X3	Fear of missing trends, time-limited buying pressure, anxiety about lost opportunities, fear of missing promotions	Przybylski et al. (2013); Elhai et al. (2021); Zhang et al. (2024)



Variable	Code	Indicators	Main Sources
User-Generated Content	X4	Content credibility, content relevance, information usefulness, review authenticity	Muntinga et al. (2018); Geng & Chen (2021)
Platform Trust	M	Transaction security, personal-data protection, system reliability, refund assurance	McKnight et al. (2002); Hajli et al. (2017); Y. Kim & Peterson (2017)
Purchase Decision	Y	Confidence in buying, firmness in product choice, final buying decision, willingness to recommend	Kotler & Keller (2016); Fatmawati et al. (2023)

4. RESULTS

4.1 Descriptive Statistics

The respondent profile shows that the sample was dominated by Generation Z consumers aged 21-23 years (62.5%), students (70.0%), respondents with monthly income or allowance between IDR 2,000,000 and IDR 5,000,000 (51.7%), and respondents from Java (55.0%). These characteristics indicate that the sample represents digitally active young consumers who are familiar with TikTok Shop and social commerce transactions.

The descriptive results show that all main constructs were perceived positively by respondents. Social proof recorded the highest average score (mean = 6.05), followed by purchase decision (mean = 5.92), platform trust (mean = 5.78), UGC (mean = 5.67), influencer marketing (mean = 5.34), and FOMO (mean = 4.80). These findings indicate that Generation Z consumers give substantial attention to social validation, user-generated information, platform reliability, and product-related information before purchasing through TikTok Shop.

Table 4. Descriptive statistics summary

Variable	Highest Indicator Mean	Lowest Indicator Mean	Average Mean	Category
Influencer Marketing	Attraction to products promoted by influencers (5.567)	Influencer content perceived as honest and natural (5.117)	5.34	High
Social Proof	Product rating affects shopping decisions (6.192)	User recommendations influence purchase decisions (5.842)	6.05	High
FOMO	Limited-time promotions encourage immediate buying (5.367)	Fear of missing viral product trends (4.200)	4.80	Moderately high
User-Generated Content	User content helps purchase decisions (6.042)	Trust in user-created reviews (5.508)	5.67	High
Platform Trust	TikTok Shop system functions well (5.875)	TikTok Shop protects personal data (5.617)	5.78	High
Purchase Decision	Confidence in buying selected products (6.025)	No hesitation in choosing products (5.783)	5.92	High

4.2 Measurement Model Evaluation

The measurement model evaluation confirms that the research instrument met the required validity and reliability criteria. All indicators had outer loading values above the acceptable threshold, with the lowest loading of 0.702 and the highest loading of 0.886. The AVE values ranged from 0.636 to 0.723, exceeding the minimum threshold of 0.50. These



results indicate adequate convergent validity. Reliability was also achieved because all Cronbach's Alpha and Composite Reliability values exceeded 0.70, indicating good internal consistency (Hair et al., 2019, 2022).

Table 5. Validity and reliability of the measurement model

Construct	Outer Loading Range	AVE	Cronbach's Alpha	Composite Reliability	Decision
Influencer Marketing	0.831-0.877	0.723	0.873	0.913	Valid and reliable
Social Proof	0.702-0.862	0.636	0.806	0.874	Valid and reliable
FOMO	0.783-0.886	0.699	0.860	0.903	Valid and reliable
User-Generated Content	0.773-0.863	0.650	0.820	0.881	Valid and reliable
Platform Trust	0.751-0.881	0.659	0.827	0.885	Valid and reliable
Purchase Decision	0.786-0.844	0.661	0.829	0.886	Valid and reliable

Discriminant validity was assessed using cross-loading and HTMT values. The cross-loading results show that each indicator loaded more strongly on its own construct than on other constructs. The HTMT results also met the recommended criterion because all values were below 0.90. The highest HTMT value was 0.819 between UGC and purchase decision, indicating that although the two constructs are related, they remain empirically distinct. The HTMT table below uses the corrected TikTok Shop construct labels and avoids duplicate platform naming.



Table 6. Heterotrait-Monotrait Ratio (HTMT)

Variable	IM	SP	FM	UGC	PT	PD
Influencer Marketing	0.850					
Social Proof	0.441	0.797				
FOMO	0.621	0.274	0.836			
User-Generated Content	0.545	0.711	0.470	0.806		
Platform Trust	0.521	0.680	0.502	0.780	0.812	
Purchase Decision	0.519	0.789	0.371	0.819	0.781	0.813

Note. IM = Influencer Marketing; SP = Social Proof; FM = FOMO; UGC = User-Generated Content; PT = Platform Trust; PD = Purchase Decision.

4.3 Structural Model Evaluation

The structural model demonstrates strong explanatory and predictive capability. The R-square value for purchase decision was 0.790, with an adjusted R-square of 0.773. This means that influencer marketing, social proof, FOMO, UGC, platform trust, and the interaction terms jointly explain 79.0% of the variance in purchase decisions, while 21.0% is explained by other variables outside the model. Based on Hair et al. (2019), this represents strong explanatory power. The f-square results show that social proof (0.182) and UGC (0.154) have medium effect sizes, while platform trust (0.095), FOMO (0.011), and influencer marketing (0.006) have small effects. The Q-square values were all greater than zero and above 0.35, indicating strong predictive relevance.

Table 7. Structural model quality indicators

Indicator	Value / Result	Interpretation
R-square for Purchase Decision	0.790	Strong explanatory power
Adjusted R-square	0.773	Strong adjusted explanatory power
f-square: Influencer Marketing	0.006	Small effect
f-square: Social Proof	0.182	Medium effect
f-square: FOMO	0.011	Small effect
f-square: User-Generated Content	0.154	Medium effect
f-square: Platform Trust	0.095	Small effect
Q-square: Purchase Decision	0.425	Strong predictive relevance

4.4 Hypothesis Testing

Hypothesis testing was conducted using bootstrapping in PLS-SEM. The direct-effect results show that social proof, UGC, and platform trust significantly affect purchase decisions, while influencer marketing and FOMO do not have significant effects. The moderating-effect results show that platform trust does not significantly moderate the relationships between any of the four independent variables and purchase decisions.

Table 8. Direct-effect hypothesis testing

Hypothesis	Relationship	Path Coefficient	t-statistic	p-value	Decision
H1	Influencer Marketing -> Purchase Decision	0.053	0.653	0.257	Rejected



Hypothesis	Relationship	Path Coefficient	t-statistic	p-value	Decision
H2	Social Proof -> Purchase Decision	0.328	3.477	<0.001	Accepted
H3	FOMO -> Purchase Decision	-0.068	1.033	0.151	Rejected
H4	UGC -> Purchase Decision	0.340	3.283	0.001	Accepted
H5	Platform Trust -> Purchase Decision	0.266	2.649	0.004	Accepted

Table 9. Moderating-effect hypothesis testing

Hypothesis	Relationship	Path Coefficient	t-statistic	p-value	Decision
H6	Platform Trust x Influencer Marketing -> Purchase Decision	0.037	0.420	0.337	Rejected
H7	Platform Trust x Social Proof -> Purchase Decision	0.057	0.622	0.267	Rejected
H8	Platform Trust x FOMO -> Purchase Decision	0.058	0.607	0.272	Rejected





Hypothesis	Relationship	Path Coefficient	t-statistic	p-value	Decision
H9	Platform Trust x UGC -> Purchase Decision	-0.128	1.156	0.124	Rejected

5. DISCUSSION

5.1 Influencer Marketing and Purchase Decision

The results show that influencer marketing does not significantly affect purchase decisions among Generation Z consumers on TikTok Shop. The path coefficient is positive but very small ($\beta = 0.053$), and the p-value is above 0.05. This means that influencer content, although visible and often attractive, does not automatically lead consumers to buy products on TikTok Shop.

This finding contrasts with Sokolova and Kefi (2020), who found that influencer credibility and parasocial interaction can influence purchase intention. The difference suggests that Generation Z consumers in this study may have become more critical toward sponsored influencer content. The descriptive results support this interpretation: the lowest influencer marketing indicator concerns the perception that influencer promotional content is honest and natural. Although the value remains moderately high, it indicates that authenticity remains a concern. In social commerce, consumers may perceive influencers as persuasive commercial actors rather than neutral product evaluators.

From the S-O-R perspective, influencer marketing is a stimulus, but the stimulus did not sufficiently activate internal consumer confidence to produce purchase decisions. This may occur because respondents, most of whom are students aged 21-23 years, are accustomed to digital advertising and may evaluate multiple information sources before buying. Their financial limitations may also make them more cautious. Therefore, influencer marketing should not be treated as a standalone strategy. Sellers should combine influencer promotion with transparent reviews, product evidence, peer validation, and clear product value.

5.2 Social Proof and Purchase Decision

Social proof has a positive and significant effect on purchase decisions. This result indicates that ratings, reviews, recommendations, comments, and the number of products sold strongly shape Generation Z consumers' confidence in products on TikTok Shop. The





path coefficient of social proof ($\beta = 0.328$) and the medium effect size ($f^2 = 0.182$) show that social validation is one of the most important predictors in the model.

This finding is consistent with Ahn and Lee (2024), Cheung and Thadani (2012), Erkan and Evans (2018), and Kwakye et al. (2024), who show that online reviews and user comments influence purchase intention by reducing uncertainty. In TikTok Shop, consumers cannot physically inspect products; therefore, social proof acts as a credibility shortcut. The descriptive data also show that product ratings received the highest mean in the social proof construct, indicating that respondents rely heavily on rating information before purchasing.

Theoretically, this result supports Social Influence Theory because consumers use the behavior and evaluations of others as references when making decisions (Kelman, 1958). It also supports the S-O-R model because social proof functions as a stimulus that affects consumer trust, perceived quality, and confidence before producing purchase decisions. For sellers, the implication is clear: product ratings, authentic comments, visible sales records, and customer recommendations are strategic assets in social commerce.

5.3 FOMO and Purchase Decision

FOMO does not significantly affect purchase decisions in this study. The relationship is negative and insignificant ($\beta = -0.068$; $p = 0.151$), indicating that fear of missing trends, limited-time promotions, or popular products does not directly increase purchase decisions among respondents. This finding differs from Alfarisi and Sukaris (2024) and Meilia Rahmawati and Komariyatin (2026), who found that FOMO can influence TikTok Shop purchase decisions.

The descriptive results help explain this finding. The highest FOMO indicator relates to limited-time promotions, but the lowest indicator concerns fear of missing viral product trends. This suggests that respondents may notice urgency-based promotions but do not necessarily buy simply because a product is viral. Generation Z consumers in this sample appear to maintain a degree of rational control, especially because many respondents are students with limited monthly allowance.

From the Technology-Driven FOMO perspective, digital urgency may create emotional pressure (Elhai et al., 2021; Przybylski et al., 2013). However, the effect of such pressure may weaken when consumers are digitally literate, price-conscious, or skeptical toward trend-based promotions. Therefore, urgency strategies such as flash sales, countdowns, and viral messaging should be supported by clear product benefits, quality evidence, and trusted user feedback rather than relying on psychological pressure alone.





5.4 User-Generated Content and Purchase Decision

UGC has a positive and significant effect on purchase decisions. Its path coefficient ($\beta = 0.340$) is the largest among the significant direct effects, and its f-square value (0.154) indicates a medium effect. This shows that user reviews, product-experience videos, comments, and authentic consumer-generated content are highly influential in encouraging purchase decisions on TikTok Shop.

This finding supports the COBRA framework, which explains that consumer-generated brand-related activities shape digital engagement and decision-making (Muntinga et al., 2018). It is also consistent with Geng and Chen (2021), who found that UGC quality affects consumers' purchase intention. In this study, the highest UGC indicator is the usefulness of information from user content. This means that respondents rely on UGC not only for entertainment, but also as a practical decision aid.

The significance of UGC also explains why influencer marketing is not significant. Generation Z consumers may perceive content from ordinary users as more realistic, less commercial, and more relatable than content from influencers. UGC can reduce uncertainty because it represents actual product use, product performance, and consumer experience. For sellers, this implies that encouraging customers to create reviews, unboxing videos, comparison content, and testimonials may be more effective than relying exclusively on paid endorsements.

5.5 Platform Trust and Purchase Decision

Platform trust has a positive and significant effect on purchase decisions. This confirms that consumers are more likely to buy products through TikTok Shop when they believe that the platform provides secure transactions, protects personal data, operates reliably, and offers fair refund mechanisms. The path coefficient ($\beta = 0.266$) demonstrates that platform trust is a meaningful direct driver of purchase decisions.

This finding is consistent with trust-based e-commerce models, which explain that trust reduces perceived risk and increases transaction confidence (D. J. Kim et al., 2008; McKnight et al., 2002). It is also consistent with Hajli et al. (2017), who emphasize the importance of trust in social commerce environments. In the descriptive results, respondents rated system reliability highest within platform trust, indicating that a smooth and dependable shopping process is an important basis for confidence.

For TikTok Shop and its sellers, this finding means that trust-building mechanisms should be treated as core marketing infrastructure. Secure payment systems, transparent product information, reliable order tracking, responsive customer service, buyer protection, and fair refund processes can strengthen purchase decisions. Trust is not merely a technical





issue; it is a behavioral determinant of whether consumers are willing to convert from product interest to actual purchase.

5.6 The Non-Significant Moderating Role of Platform Trust

The moderation results show that platform trust does not significantly moderate the effects of influencer marketing, social proof, FOMO, or UGC on purchase decisions. H6, H7, H8, and H9 are all rejected. This means that while platform trust directly influences purchase decisions, it does not strengthen or weaken the relationships between the four digital stimuli and purchase decisions.

This result suggests that platform trust operates more as an independent decision factor than as a boundary condition in this research context. Consumers may separately evaluate whether TikTok Shop is safe and reliable, while also separately evaluating product-related social information such as reviews, ratings, and UGC. In other words, trust in the platform increases confidence to transact, but it does not necessarily make influencer content, social proof, FOMO, or UGC more persuasive.

The non-significant moderating effects also indicate that the persuasive force of social proof and UGC is strong enough to influence decisions directly, regardless of the level of platform trust. Conversely, influencer marketing and FOMO remain insignificant even when platform trust is considered. This reinforces the conclusion that Generation Z consumers in this study prioritize authentic product evidence and direct platform credibility over persuasive endorsements or urgency-based emotional pressure.

6. CONCLUSION

This study examined the effects of influencer marketing, social proof, FOMO, and UGC on purchase decisions on TikTok Shop, with platform trust as a moderating variable among Generation Z consumers in Indonesia. Based on data from 120 respondents analyzed using PLS-SEM, the study concludes that influencer marketing does not significantly affect purchase decisions. Although influencer content attracts attention, Generation Z consumers do not rely solely on influencer recommendations when deciding to purchase products on TikTok Shop.

Social proof has a positive and significant effect on purchase decisions. Ratings, reviews, comments, recommendations, and sales volume provide social validation that helps consumers reduce uncertainty and increase confidence. FOMO does not significantly affect purchase decisions, indicating that urgency, viral trends, and fear of missing promotions do not directly drive purchase behavior among respondents. UGC has a positive and significant effect on purchase decisions, demonstrating that consumer-created reviews and experience-





based content are important sources of credible information. Platform trust also has a positive and significant effect on purchase decisions, confirming that secure transactions, personal-data protection, system reliability, and refund assurance increase consumers' confidence to buy.

Platform trust does not significantly moderate the effects of influencer marketing, social proof, FOMO, or UGC on purchase decisions. Therefore, platform trust in this study functions more as a direct antecedent of purchase decisions than as a moderating mechanism. Overall, the findings show that Generation Z consumers on TikTok Shop are more influenced by peer validation, authentic user experience, and platform credibility than by influencer persuasion or FOMO-based pressure.

7. IMPLICATIONS AND SUGGESTIONS

7.1 Theoretical Implications

Theoretically, this study contributes to digital consumer behavior and social commerce literature by showing that different digital stimuli do not have equal effects on purchase decisions. The significant effects of social proof and UGC support the S-O-R model and Social Influence Theory, indicating that peer-based information and user-created content can act as strong external stimuli that shape internal confidence and lead to purchase decisions. The significant direct role of platform trust also supports online trust theory, which emphasizes trust as a mechanism for reducing risk in digital transactions.

The non-significant effects of influencer marketing and FOMO extend prior literature by showing that Generation Z consumers may be more critical and selective in evaluating social commerce stimuli. This suggests a shift from persuasion-based and urgency-based consumption toward evidence-based and trust-based decision-making. The non-significant moderation findings also indicate that platform trust may not always function as a strengthening mechanism; in this context, it operates as an independent determinant of purchase decisions.

7.2 Managerial Implications

For TikTok Shop sellers, the findings suggest that social proof and UGC should be prioritized as strategic marketing assets. Sellers should actively encourage satisfied customers to provide ratings, detailed reviews, comments, photos, videos, and testimonials. Authentic post-purchase content can strengthen consumer confidence because it is perceived as more realistic and credible than seller-generated messages.

TikTok Shop as a platform should continue improving transaction security, personal-data protection, system reliability, transparency, and refund processes. Trust-building





features are critical because platform trust directly affects purchase decisions. Sellers should also provide clear product descriptions, transparent pricing, responsive customer service, and consistent delivery quality to complement platform-level trust.

Influencer marketing should be used more selectively. Instead of choosing influencers only based on follower count or popularity, sellers should consider influencer credibility, product relevance, audience fit, and authenticity. FOMO-based tactics such as limited-time promotions should also be integrated with product quality, evidence-based information, and user reviews to avoid creating short-term attention without actual purchase conversion.

7.3 Limitations and Future Research

This study has several limitations. First, the sample focuses only on Generation Z TikTok Shop users, so the results may not be generalizable to other generations or other e-commerce platforms. Second, the study includes only influencer marketing, social proof, FOMO, UGC, and platform trust, while purchase decisions may also be affected by other variables such as electronic word-of-mouth, live streaming shopping, brand image, customer engagement, customer experience, price discounts, or perceived product quality. Third, the use of an online questionnaire means that the findings rely on self-reported perceptions.

Future studies are encouraged to expand respondent coverage, compare different social commerce platforms, and include additional variables. A qualitative or mixed-method approach would also be useful to explore deeper psychological motivations and consumer experiences behind purchase decisions in social commerce environments.

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